VUGA NDAKUMVA INITIATIVE

CHAPTER 03
Root Causes, Risk Factors, and Gender Inequality

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Educational status: Evidence-informed draft for learning and community awareness. It is not a substitute for individualized legal, medical, psychological, or protection advice. Requires specialist safeguarding, legal and Rwanda localization review before public release.

Chapter purpose and learning outcomes

Gender-based violence (GBV) does not emerge from one simple cause. This chapter helps readers understand how unequal power relations and harmful gender norms create conditions that permit violence, how risk factors operate at different levels, and how families, schools, communities, services, and institutions can reduce harm. It also explains why identifying a risk factor never justifies blaming a survivor.

- Explain gender inequality, power and coercive control in plain language.
- Distinguish root causes from risk factors, triggers, protective factors, and individual accountability.
- Apply the ecological model to illustrative Rwandan settings without stereotyping communities.
- Recognize prevention strategies with stronger evidence and avoid unsafe interventions.
- Practice respectful, survivor-centred responses and identify when specialist help is needed.

1. Understanding what drives GBV

GBV refers to harmful acts linked to gender-based expectations, discrimination, or unequal power relations. Research on violence against women and girls consistently identifies gender inequality as a structural driver, especially when beliefs about entitlement, control, and obedience make abuse seem acceptable or inevitable [1,2]. Other people, including men and boys, may experience gender-related abuse and deserve equally respectful support.

It is useful to separate the conditions that allow violence from the decision to commit violence. A setting may tolerate intimidation or unequal authority; nevertheless, an individual who uses violence is responsible for that conduct. Poverty, alcohol use, jealousy, disagreement, or cultural tradition are never excuses.

Three concepts that should not be confused

Concept	Meaning and example
Root or structural driver	A broad, persistent condition that supports GBV, such as norms accepting control of women or unequal access to decision-making.
Risk factor	A circumstance statistically associated with greater likelihood of violence, such as prior exposure to family violence; not a prediction about one person.
Protective factor	A condition that may reduce risk, such as equitable relationships, accessible survivor services, or effective institutional accountability.

2. Gender inequality and unequal power

Gender inequality describes unequal rights, opportunities, resources, expectations or influence associated with gender. It can operate through everyday decisions about who may study, work, own property, travel, speak in public, control money, or refuse sexual activity. The relationship to GBV becomes especially concerning when someone treats these inequalities as a right to dominate another person [1,3].

Power itself is not violence. Parents, teachers, managers and public officials may hold legitimate responsibilities. Abuse occurs when a person misuses authority to threaten, exploit, isolate, humiliate, coerce, or harm someone. A manager who links a job opportunity to unwanted sexual conduct is misusing professional power. A partner who blocks access to shared finances to force obedience is using economic control.

Formal equality matters, but written rights do not by themselves eliminate harmful practices. Effective prevention also changes behavior, accountability, access to resources, and what people consider acceptable in everyday relationships.

3. Harmful norms and learned beliefs

Social norms are shared expectations about what people in a group typically do or approve of. Some norms protect dignity and collective care. Others create risk when they say that a partner must always obey, that jealousy proves love, that boys must be aggressive to be respected, or that reporting violence dishonors a family.

Children can learn these expectations through observation, jokes, peer pressure, media messages, social institutions, and how adults respond to conflict. However, seeing violence in childhood does not mean a person will inevitably become violent. It indicates a possible risk that supportive relationships, education and intervention can help address [2,4].

Common harmful messages and healthier alternatives

Harmful message	Healthier principle
"A partner must obey without question."	Adults have equal dignity and may express disagreement without fear.
"Real men must control the household."	Responsibility and care do not require coercion or domination.
"Family matters should never be discussed outside."	Privacy matters, but seeking safe support for violence is legitimate.
"If someone stays, the abuse cannot be serious."	Leaving may create danger or involve housing, childcare, and financial barriers.

4. The ecological model: four connected levels

The social-ecological model used in public health examines how influences interact at the individual, relationship, community, and societal levels [2,4]. No single level explains every incident. Prevention becomes stronger when actions address several levels at once.

Level	Examples of concerns	Possible protective response
Individual	Attitudes condoning abuse; prior exposure to violence; harmful alcohol use in some contexts.	Nonviolent conflict skills, respectful gender education, accessible support.
Relationship	Controlling behavior, extreme power imbalance, threats, isolation.	Equitable decision-making and intervention addressing perpetration.
Community	Harassment tolerated at school or work; barriers to reporting; unsafe public spaces.	Safe complaint channels, bystander responsibility, trained staff.
Societal	Discriminatory practices, weak enforcement, norms accepting GBV.	Equality policies, accountable institutions, long-term norm change.

Risk factors in a table are not labels to attach to individuals. A person experiencing unemployment or a mental health difficulty should never be assumed to be violent or likely to experience abuse. Assessment must be grounded in actual behavior and context.

5. Social and institutional influences

Families and intimate relationships

Where household roles give one person exclusive control over money, mobility, decisions, or communication, others may have fewer safe options. Unequal expectations about unpaid caregiving and earning income can reinforce dependency. Equal decision-making and accessible independent resources can reduce vulnerability without implying that every unequal household has violence.

Schools and universities

Rigid expectations about girls and boys, harassment dismissed as normal, and unequal power between learners and staff can contribute to risk. Prevention includes clear safeguarding codes, accessible confidential reporting, staff training, age-appropriate consent education, and protection against retaliation. Schools must not force survivors into public disclosures or face-to-face mediation with alleged perpetrators.

Workplaces and economic settings

Risks can emerge where supervisors can demand personal favors, threaten job loss, or manipulate pay and promotion. Effective measures include clear harassment policies, independent reporting channels, protection against retaliation, impartial investigation, and access to support. General awareness training without accountable procedures is insufficient.

Community and service institutions

Community leaders, health workers, police, justice actors and faith leaders can support prevention when they refuse victim-blaming, protect confidentiality within its legal limits, and refer people appropriately. They can also cause harm if they pressure a survivor to reconcile, insist on a disclosure, or expose private information.

6. Economic pressures: association is not justification

Poverty, job insecurity, unequal control of assets, and inadequate access to housing or transport may intensify vulnerability or make it harder to leave an unsafe relationship. The evidence associates economic stress with some violence risks, but poverty does not automatically produce violence, nor are people experiencing economic hardship inherently abusive [1,5].

Financial empowerment can increase choice, but an intervention that changes household power dynamics may sometimes produce backlash. Programs should combine economic opportunities with gender-transformative approaches, consent, safety assessment, and routes to specialized support rather than assume that giving someone money alone guarantees safety.

7. Alcohol, substances, and violence

Harmful alcohol use is associated with some forms of violence and may intensify risk in particular circumstances [1,5]. However, many people who drink do not become violent, and many perpetrators use violence without consuming alcohol. The decision to threaten or assault someone remains the perpetrator’s responsibility.

Prevention may include access to treatment for harmful substance use and measures that reduce hazardous drinking, but substance treatment should not replace accountability or protection for a person experiencing abuse.

8. Risk factors versus warning signs

A risk factor is a population-level association. A warning sign is a specific behavior or circumstance that may indicate abuse in a particular setting. Confusing the two can lead to discrimination or false reassurance.

Risk factor (association)	Warning sign (behavior to take seriously)
Prior exposure to violence in childhood.	A partner repeatedly threatens harm if someone talks to friends.
Economic insecurity.	A partner confiscates wages or blocks access to essential money.
Harmful norms supporting dominance.	A supervisor demands sexual favors in exchange for a grade or job.
Weak reporting systems.	Staff dismiss a disclosure or warn the survivor not to complain.

Warning signs should lead to safe options and appropriate support, not public accusations or confrontations organized by untrained people. If someone is in immediate danger, urgent local assistance takes priority over educational discussion.

9. Protective factors and resilience

Protective conditions include relationships based on mutual respect; norms that reject violence; access to education and economic opportunities; trustworthy health, legal and psychosocial support; and rules that are fairly enforced [2,5]. No protective factor can guarantee that violence will never occur.

Supportive families and communities can reduce isolation, but survivors should retain control over whom they involve whenever possible. A person should not be required to disclose to a relative, partner, religious leader or community meeting before seeking specialist help.

10. Prevention based on evidence: the RESPECT framework

WHO and partners' updated 2025 RESPECT framework identifies seven complementary approaches to preventing violence against women [2]. It is a population-level prevention framework, not a checklist for making an unsafe relationship safe.

- R - Relationship skills strengthened: Teach respectful communication, nonviolent problem-solving and equitable decision-making.

- E - Empowerment of women: Improve meaningful access to education, resources, choices and leadership.
- S - Services ensured: Provide safe, quality survivor-centred health, psychosocial, protection and legal services.
- P - Poverty reduced: Address economic insecurity with attention to safety and gender dynamics.
- E - Environments made safe: Reduce harassment and threats in public, school, work and digital spaces.
- C - Child and adolescent abuse prevented: Strengthen child protection and nonviolent caregiving.
- T - Transformed attitudes, beliefs and norms: Challenge beliefs excusing violence and promote equal dignity.

Programs should evaluate outcomes, not just count training sessions. Useful measures may include changes in acceptance of violence, safety of reporting, quality of referrals, implementation of protections, and carefully collected reports of harm. Collecting survivor disclosures for monitoring must never compromise confidentiality.

11. Rwanda relevance: local systems and approaches

Rwanda's National Policy against Gender-Based Violence identifies prevention, survivor response, coordination and accountability as core areas [6]. A newer national strategy engaging men and boys emphasizes transforming harmful gender norms and promoting equitable responsibilities [3]. These documents provide useful local grounding, but a program must confirm current legal duties, operational procedures and official referral contacts with responsible national institutions.

For VUGA NDAKUMVA, examples should reflect the diversity of Rwandan settings: urban and rural households, schools, informal work, agriculture, workplaces, and digital communication. Avoid presenting any district, cultural practice, occupation, age group, or income bracket as inherently violent.

When someone asks for GBV help, direct them to verified local specialist support, including Isange One Stop Centres where available, while taking their immediate safety and privacy into account. Do not publish unverified hotlines or promise that all providers offer identical services at all hours.

12. Realistic learning scenarios

Scenario A - Household decisions and financial control

A woman begins a paid job. Her partner insists that all her earnings be handed over, refuses to let her buy transport to work, and threatens to take her phone if she disagrees. Discussion: Distinguish an ordinary budget disagreement from coercive control. The threats and enforced restrictions, rather than the existence of different financial opinions, are the concern. A safe response would explore options privately and avoid confronting the partner without a safety plan.

Scenario B - School authority and retaliation

A student reports that a staff member repeatedly requests private meetings and implies that marks may depend on compliance. Classmates tell the student not to speak because the staff member is influential. Discussion: Identify abuse of authority, protective reporting arrangements, and why consent may be undermined by coercion. Safeguarding procedures must be appropriate to the learner's age and local law.

Scenario C - Men and boys challenging norms

A youth club hears the claim that jealousy is proof of love and that controlling a partner's friends is normal. Members discuss how fear, monitoring, and isolation differ from care. Discussion: How might peers challenge harmful beliefs without shaming individuals or asking survivors to share personal experiences?

Scenario D - Community mediation pressure

A person discloses threats from a partner to a community volunteer. The volunteer wants both partners to attend a meeting immediately. Discussion: Why could joint mediation expose the survivor to retaliation? What would confidential listening, choice-based referrals, and careful safety assessment look like instead?

Scenario E - Work and economic vulnerability

A temporary worker is told by a supervisor that a contract renewal depends on agreeing to unwanted personal contact. The worker fears losing income. Discussion: Identify institutional power and possible retaliation; consider how independent workplace procedures and external support improve options.

13. Practical learning activities

Activity 1 - Map influences without blaming

Choose a fictional scenario and write four headings: individual, relationship, community and societal. Under each, identify one condition that may increase risk and one possible protective response. Avoid writing anyone's name or inviting participants to describe their own abuse experiences. Reflection: Which changes require institutional action rather than asking one person to cope alone?

Activity 2 - Challenge a harmful statement

Select a statement such as "A person who pays the bills should control every decision." Write a respectful response that distinguishes shared financial planning from domination. Practice responding without insulting or embarrassing anyone. Sample: "Contributing money does not give someone the right to threaten or control another adult."

Activity 3 - Design a safer institution

Imagine a school or workplace. Identify three safety features: a trustworthy reporting route, protection against retaliation, and confidential referral to trained services. Then identify one risk if these features exist only on paper. Safety note: Do not conduct role-play requiring a participant to impersonate a survivor or perpetrator.

Activity 4 - Personal values reflection

Privately reflect on how disagreements were handled in the environments where you grew up. Which messages encouraged respect? Which normalized domination? There is no need to share answers. If the exercise causes distress, pause and choose another activity.

Activity 5 - Community prevention planning

In a small group, design an awareness activity using fictional examples. Include an evidence-based message, accessible language, an opt-out option, and an independently verified referral pathway. Decide how you will measure understanding without collecting sensitive personal disclosures.

14. Supporting a person safely

A person asking about GBV may be seeking general knowledge or may be living with current danger. An educator should avoid guessing. Offer a choice to continue learning or discuss safe help-seeking, do not ask for unnecessary details, and explain confidentiality and its limits. A survivor should never be blamed for a decision to stay, leave, report, or delay action.

- Listen and acknowledge: “Thank you for telling me. You deserve to be treated safely and respectfully.”
- Ask about immediate needs without demanding a detailed account.
- Offer options and verified contacts, rather than issuing commands.
- Avoid confronting an alleged perpetrator, pressuring reconciliation, or arranging unsupervised mediation.
- If danger is immediate, help connect to appropriate emergency or specialist services, taking care not to increase risk.

15. Safe communication and sensitive data

Education and outreach must consider that a controlling person may access another person’s phone or browsing history. Public materials should not assume that a user can safely keep an app open, receive notifications, or save phone numbers. Digital safety measures may help, but no quick-exit feature can guarantee that browsing history or monitoring has been erased.

For workshops and surveys, do not collect real-life disclosures as a learning requirement. If someone voluntarily discloses violence, follow an approved safeguarding protocol. For minors, follow locally applicable child-protection and reporting obligations, explained in an age-appropriate way.

16. Knowledge assessment

1. Is poverty a sufficient explanation or excuse for GBV?
Suggested answer: No. Economic insecurity may affect risk or options, but does not justify abuse.

2. What is a structural driver?
Suggested answer: A broad condition, such as gender inequality or norms tolerating domination, that supports violence risk.

3. What four levels appear in the ecological model?
Suggested answer: Individual, relationship, community, and societal.

4. Does witnessing violence as a child determine adult behavior?
Suggested answer: No. It can be a risk factor, not an inevitable outcome.

5. Give one example of coercive control.
Suggested answer: Repeated threats, forced isolation, surveillance, or deprivation of necessary resources to control another person.

6. What makes a reporting system safer?
Suggested answer: Confidentiality within legal limits, staff training, protection against retaliation, and credible follow-through.

7. Name two RESPECT prevention strategies.
Suggested answer: Any two: relationship skills, empowerment, services, poverty reduction, safe environments, child abuse prevention, transformed norms.

8. Why can forced couple mediation be unsafe in abusive situations?
Suggested answer: It may expose a survivor to coercion, retaliation, and further harm.

9. Does having a mental health condition mean someone will commit GBV?
Suggested answer: No. Population-level associations must never be used to stereotype individuals.

10. What is the first principle when receiving a disclosure?
Suggested answer: Respect the person’s safety, dignity, privacy and choices; listen without judgment.

17. Key messages to remember

- Gender inequality and harmful norms are central structural drivers of violence against women and girls.
- Risk factors describe associations, not destiny or moral blame.
- Abusive conduct remains the responsibility of the person committing it.
- Multiple levels of prevention are stronger than awareness messages alone.
- Survivor safety, consent, dignity and privacy should guide every response.
- Rwandan programs should combine verified national guidance with local specialist review.

18. Short glossary

Gender inequality: Unequal access to opportunities, resources, rights or influence on the basis of gender.

Gender norm: A socially shared expectation about how people of different genders should behave.

Coercive control: A pattern of threatening, isolating or restricting behavior aimed at dominating someone.

Risk factor: A condition associated with increased likelihood of an outcome in research.

Protective factor: A condition associated with reduced risk or increased safety.

Ecological model: A framework that considers individual, relationship, community and societal influences.

Survivor-centred: An approach prioritizing the person’s dignity, safety, rights, privacy and informed choices.

Prevention: Actions designed to reduce the occurrence of violence and the conditions that enable it.

19. Evidence and references

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[4] World Health Organization. Violence Prevention Unit strategy 2022-2026: Social ecological model.

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[5] UN Women. Handbook on Multisectoral National Action Plans to Prevent Violence Against Women and Girls. 2023.

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[6] MIGEPROF Rwanda. National Policy Against Gender-Based Violence. 2011 (historical policy reference; verify current operational requirements).

https://www.migeprof.gov.rw/fileadmin/user_upload/Migeprof/Publications/Guidelines/National_Policy_against_Gender-Based_Violence-2011.pdf

20. Publication readiness checklist

- [ ] GBV prevention specialist has reviewed conceptual and educational accuracy.
- [ ] Rwanda-qualified legal/safeguarding reviewer has verified reporting duties and terminology.
- [ ] All actual referral contacts and service hours are checked at publication time.
- [ ] Clinical reviewer has checked mental-health-related safety language.
- [ ] English, Kinyarwanda and French versions receive independent human review.
- [ ] Accessibility, privacy and safe-device-use checks are completed.
- [ ] Content owner, revision date and next review date are recorded.

Next chapter: Chapter 04 - Understanding Consent, Boundaries, and Bodily Autonomy. This chapter should be expanded only as a separate GBV educational publication; Chapter 03 remains in draft until approved.